Nagaland as the lead characters investigated a local politician's murder.

A WHOLE NEW WORLD

Ask *Paatal Lok* creator Sudip Sharma what drove him to the region and he tells you that having grown up and studied in Guwahati, he was always enamoured of a part of India that was little known or spoken about, especially in mainstream Indian cinema. "It's incredibly rich culturally," says Sharma. "For me, it was to discover it in greater detail. To go to a place we've never seen on screen, as in nothing's been set there...at best, it has been a reference."

Much the same impulse drives Nikhil Madhok, head of Originals, Prime Video India. Shows like *Paatal Lok* and *The Last Hour*, which was shot in Sikkim, have only made the platform's programming slate more varied, showcasing "an often underrepresented side of India" and, hopefully, also its "social fabric". "Our focus has always been on fresh, locally rooted narratives set across India," says Madhok. "Projects like these reflect our commitment to telling diverse stories and exploring the region's rich heritage in depth. Authenticity is key—we cast local artistes in both, bringing incredible talent both on and off screen."

But it isn't just curiosity and the need for diversity that has Mumbai crews flocking to the region. The improved law and order and road connectivity, too, have contributed to a rise in shoots in places like Assam and Nagaland. "Earlier, because of militant groups, the perception was that the Northeast is unsafe," says Handique, who runs Zeymz Visions, which boasts credits like the Varun Dhawan-starrer horror comedy *Bhediya* and Vishal Bhardwaj's *Rangoon*, both shot in Arunachal Pradesh. "People were hesitant to come here. But once they did, their outlook completely changed."

Simanta Shekhar, chairman of the Assam State Film Finance & Development Corporation, attributes Bollywood's growing fascination to the "state-of-the-art roads and five bridges over the Brahmaputra". "There's single-window clearance now for all shooting purposes," says Shekhar. "If they [filmmakers] want to shoot in Assam, the state government will help them in every way. Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma is keen to have guests from the film industry here."





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AN IDYLLIC LAND

Such openness is welcome and pivotal, for Assam operates as the gateway to other northeastern states. Guwahati runs frequent flights to Itanagar, Shillong, Dimapur and Aizawl, but there are also other airports in the state—Silchar, Dhubri, Dibrugarh, Jorhat, Tezpur and Lakhimpur. Tezpur, which hosts the headquarters of the IV Corps of the Indian Army and also an air force base, has in particular become a favoured destination for action-based projects. Remember Hrithik Roshan and Deepika Padukone in *Fighter*? ZEE5 web series *Jaanbaaz* was also shot here. A singer by profession, Shekhar says virgin locations and a safe environment have made the Northeast a winning combo for the studios. The safety factor extends even to the narratives set there. As titles with political and historical themes become the targets of the fringe and the censor board, stories unfolding in a less-known region help avoid controversy and, subsequently, backlash.

The low density of population also makes crowd control at outdoor locations easier. As Handique says, "The people of the Northeast think more with their hearts than with their minds. People are cooperative during shoots."